

Japanese temples

Japanese Shinto shrines are dwellings for the gods, the *kami*. Sacred objects that represent them may be stored out of sight in the *honden*, or inner sanctuary, but a *honden* may not be present if there are altar-like structures called *himorogi* nearby. Buddhist temples also exist alongside Shinto shrines, with both sharing some features of Japanese traditional architecture (although Buddhist architecture was brought to Japan from China and other Asian cultures, and so is somewhat eclectic).

Partly due to these diverse origins and partly in response to the differing climates across Japan, shrines vary in structure, but some features recur. Most Japanese temples are made of wood to be earthquake-proof, and, although borrowing from Chinese architectural designs, have their own distinctive characteristics. Gently curving roofs are common, supported by a post-and-lintel structure, with walls that are paper-thin and often movable, making inner spaces fluid.



Toshogu Shrine at Nikko, 1617